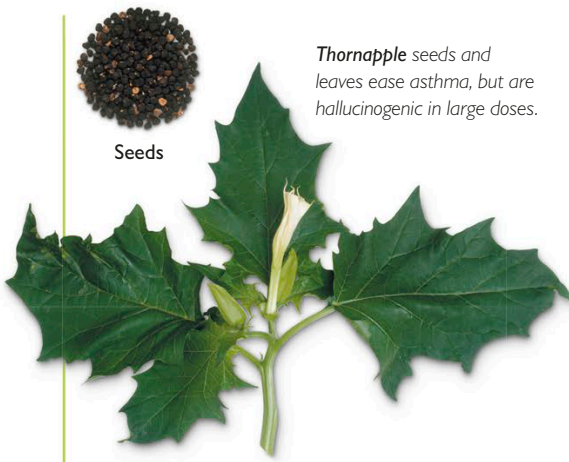




Thornapple seeds and leaves ease asthma, but are hallucinogenic in large doses.

Seeds

Constituents Thornapple contains 0.2–0.45% tropane alkaloids (especially hyoscyamine and hyoscyne), flavonoids, steroidal lactones, withanolides, coumarins, and tannins. The tropane alkaloids are similar to those found in deadly nightshade (*Atropa belladonna*, p. 69), acting to reduce secretions and relax smooth muscle.

History & Folklore Thornapple has a long history of medicinal use. If taken in sufficient doses, it causes hallucinations; the Delphic oracle in ancient Greece and the Inca in South America may have used it as an aid to making prophecies. Though it is hallucinogenic, thornapple has traditionally been used to treat insanity.

Medicinal Actions & Uses At low doses, thornapple is a common remedy for asthma, whooping cough, muscle spasms, and the symptoms of Parkinsonism. It relaxes the muscles of the gastrointestinal, bronchial, and urinary tracts, and reduces digestive and mucous secretions. Like deadly nightshade, thornapple may be applied externally to relieve rheumatic pains and neuralgia.

Related Species *D. metel* and *D. innoxia* are both native to India. These plants are employed in treating asthma, coughs, fevers, and skin conditions.

⚠️ Cautions Take only under professional supervision. Since it is toxic at more than small doses, thornapple is subject to legal restrictions in most countries.

Daucus carota (Apiaceae)

Carrot

Description Annual (cultivated varieties) or biennial (wild). Has erect stem, which grows to a height of 3 ft (1 m), with feathery leaves, small white flowers, and flat green seeds. Cultivated subspecies have fleshy orange taproots.

Habitat & Cultivation Wild carrot is native to Europe, although cultivated subspecies are now grown around the world. The root is harvested in late summer, and the seeds are gathered in late summer or early autumn.

Parts Used Seeds, root, leaves.

Constituents Wild carrot seeds contain flavonoids, and a volatile oil including asarone, carotol, pinene, and limonene. Cultivated carrot root contains sugars, pectin, carotene, vitamins, minerals, and asparagine. Carrot leaves contain significant amounts of porphyrins, which stimulate the pituitary gland and lead to the release of increased levels of sex hormones.

History & Folklore The origins of the familiar garden carrot are a mystery—it was cultivated as a nutritious and cleansing food at least as long ago as ancient Greece and Rome. In the 1st century CE, the physician Dioscorides recommended the seeds to stimulate menstruation, to relieve urinary retention, and to “wake up the genital virtue.” The cultivated variety did not reach Britain until the 16th century, when women used its beautiful, finely divided leaves to adorn their hair.

Medicinal Actions & Uses This common vegetable is also a wonderfully cleansing medicine. It supports the liver, and stimulates urine flow and the removal of waste by the kidneys. The juice of organically grown carrots is a delicious drink and a valuable detoxifier. Carrots are rich in carotene, which is converted to vitamin A by the liver. The raw root, grated or mashed, is a safe treatment for threadworms, especially in children. Wild carrot leaves are a good diuretic. They have been used to counter cystitis and kidney stone formation, and to diminish stones that have already formed. The seeds are also diuretic. They stimulate menstruation and have been used in folk medicine as a treatment for hangovers. Both leaves and seeds relieve flatulence and settle the digestion.

Research In a study published in 1995, a carrot extract was shown to protect the liver from toxicity.

Cautions Do not take carrot seeds during pregnancy. Use only organic carrot juice since the root concentrates artificial fertilizers and insecticides.

Desmodium adscendens (Fabaceae)

Desmodium

Description Perennial, much-branched herb, growing to 20 in (50 cm). Desmodium has light purple flowers, and the leaves each have three small oval leaflets.

Habitat & Cultivation A native of West Africa, including Sierra Leone, northern Liberia and Ghana. The aerial parts are harvested as required or after flowering.

Parts Used Leaves and stems.

Constituents Contains indole alkaloids.

History & Folklore Desmodium has long been used in West African herbal medicine as a treatment for asthma, and also for jaundice.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Desmodium is chiefly a remedy for asthma and has been used as an antiasthmatic in Ghanaian hospitals. In France, the herb is taken for liver disorders including viral hepatitis—both A and B—apparently having most effect during the early stages. Desmodium may also be used to relieve headache, backache, and muscle and joint pain—a decoction being taken internally or applied as a lotion.

Research Ghanaian research has shown the herb to have antispasmodic and antiasthmatic activity. It also appears to increase the resistance of liver cells to inflammation, whether resulting from infection or toxicity. When taken in the early stages of illness, it normalizes liver function.

Caution In rare cases, desmodium can cause nausea or diarrhea.

Dianthus superbus (Caryophyllaceae) Fringed Pink, Qu Mai (Chinese)

Description Upright perennial herb growing to 32 in (80 cm) or more. Has narrow, lance-shaped leaves and large, delicate, fragrant pink or lilac flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Fringed pink is native to Europe and northern Asia (including China and Japan) growing at altitudes of up to 7,900 ft (2,400 m). It grows in clumps on hillsides and crevices, and is cultivated from seed in eastern China. It is only harvested when in flower.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Fringed pink contains saponins, dianthins, tannins and flavonoids.

History & Folklore Fringed pink is first mentioned in the Chinese herbal known as the *Divine Husbandman's Classic* (*Shen'ong Bencaojing*), which was written in the 1st century CE.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Although fringed pink is common in Europe, there is little indication that people there have used it as anything other than a vegetable (the young leaves are best boiled or steamed). In Mongolia, it is used to promote contractions and childbirth, and is considered a diuretic, hemostatic, and anti-inflammatory. In Chinese medicine it is widely used for “damp-heat” conditions, and prescribed for kidney stones and urinary tract infections.

Research Research, mostly conducted in Korea and China, indicates that fringed pink has marked anti-inflammatory activity and possible cancer-fighting properties.

Related Species The gillyflower (*D. caryophyllus*), of Mediterranean origin, has similar constituents and is traditionally prescribed in European herbal medicine for coronary and nervous disorders.